

Word family: **first** / firstly / first-hand / first-class

Base word: first

Related forms / useful extensions: firstly, first-hand, first-class

Useful expressions: first of all, at first, for the first time, first and foremost, first thing, come first, put someone/something first

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / adverb (副詞) / noun (名詞)

Your sentence:

> “Instead, she listens **first** and then gives simple but thoughtful advice.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **first** means **before doing anything else; as the initial step in a sequence**.

Your grandmother does not immediately judge or advise. She **listens before she responds**.

繁體中文： **在一連串行動中最先進行；先.....，然後才做下一件事**

中文翻譯：

> “Instead, she listens first and then gives simple but thoughtful advice.”

「相反，她總是**先聽**，然後才給我一些簡單但很有分量的建議。」

Here:

listen first = 先聆聽，在作出回應或給意見之前先了解對方

1. **first = before anything else (順序) — 首先；先**

This is the exact sense in your passage.

Practice 1 — Original

> “She listens **first** and then gives advice.”

「她會**先聽**，然後才給建議。」

Practice 2

> “Think **first** before you answer.”

「回答之前要**先想一想**。」

Practice 3

> “Wash your hands **first**.”

「**先**洗手。」

first = 在一連串行動中最先進行，之後才進行其他事情

2. **first + noun (次序第一) — 第一個 / 第一項的**

Here **first** functions adjectivally.

Practice 4

> “She was the **first person** to arrive.”

「她是**第一個到達的人**。」

Practice 5

> “The **first question** was easy.”

「**第一條問題**很容易。」

first + noun = 在順序、時間或排列上位於最前面的

3. **the first = first person/thing (第一個) — 第一個；最先的一個**

Practice 6

> “She was the **first** to speak.”

「她是**第一個發言的人**。」

Practice 7

> “This was the **first** of three meetings.”

「這是三次會議中的**第一次**。」

****the first = 在某組人、事物或事件中排最前的一個****

4. ****first = earliest in time (最早的) — 最早的 ; 首次的****

Practice 8

> “I still remember my ****first day**** at school.”

「我仍然記得上學的****第一天****。」

Practice 9

> “That was my ****first visit**** to the city.”

「那是我****第一次到訪****那座城市。」

****first = 某件事情最早發生的一次 / 階段****

5. ****for the first time — 第一次****

A major fixed expression.

Practice 10

> “I met her ****for the first time**** when I was young.”

「我小時候****第一次****見到她。」

Practice 11

> “She travelled alone ****for the first time****.”

「她****第一次****獨自旅行。」

****for the first time = 某件事以前從未發生過，這次是首次****

6. ****at first = initially (起初) — 起初 ; 一開始****

A very important expression.

Practice 12

> “**At first**, she seemed quiet.”

「**起初**，她看起來很安靜。」

Practice 13

> “I didn’t understand it **at first**.”

「我**一開始**並不明白。」

at first = 在事情開始的階段；後來情況可能有所改變

7. **first of all = 首先**

A common discourse expression.

Practice 14

> “**First of all**, we need to understand the problem.”

「**首先**，我們需要了解問題。」

Practice 15

> “**First of all**, thank you for coming.”

「**首先**，謝謝大家到來。」

first of all = 用來引出一連串內容、理由或步驟中的第一項

8. **firstly = firstly / in the first place (首先) — 首先**

A more formal organizing adverb.

Practice 16

> “**Firstly**, we need more information.”

「**首先**，我們需要更多資料。」

Practice 17

> “**Firstly**, the plan is too expensive.”

「**首先**，這個計劃太昂貴。」

firstly = 用來列出第一個論點、原因或步驟

Common pairings:

* firstly

* secondly

* finally

9. **first and foremost** = most importantly (首要地) — 首先而且最重要的是

Practice 18

> “She is **first and foremost** a caring person.”

「她**首先而且最重要的是**一個很關心別人的人。」

Practice 19

> “Safety must come **first and foremost**.”

「安全必須是**首要而最重要的考慮**。」

first and foremost = 在所有考慮中最重要、最優先

10. **come first** = have highest priority (最優先) — 放在首位；最重要

Practice 20

> “Family comes **first** for her.”

「對她來說，家庭**最重要 / 放在首位**。」

Practice 21

> “Safety should always come **first**.”

「安全應該永遠**放在第一位**。」

****come first = 在重要性或優先次序上高於其他事情****

This is no longer just chronological order.

11. ****put someone/something first — 把……放在首位****

Practice 22

> “She always ****puts her family first****.”

「她總是把家人****放在首位****。」

Practice 23

> “Good leaders ****put people first****.”

「好的領導者會把人****放在第一位****。」

****put someone/something first = 優先考慮某人的需要或某件事情的重要性****

12. ****first priority / first concern (首要事項) — 首要；最優先****

Practice 24

> “Her ****first priority**** is her family.”

「她的****首要考慮****是家人。」

Practice 25

> “Patient safety is our ****first concern****.”

「病人安全是我們的****首要關注事項****。」

****first = 在重要性或優先程度上位於最高位置****

13. ****first place — 第一名 / 首位****

Practice 26

> “She finished in **first place**.”

「她取得**第一名**。」

Practice 27

> “The team moved into **first place**.”

「球隊升上**第一位**。」

first place = 比賽、排名或競爭中的最高位置

14. **come first / finish first** (比賽) — 得第一；最先完成

Practice 28

> “She **came first** in the race.”

「她在比賽中**取得第一名**。」

Practice 29

> “He **finished first**.”

「他**第一個完成 / 奪得第一名**。」

first = 在競賽或完成順序中排在所有其他人之前

15. **first** = highest quality / best category (第一流) — 上等的；最好的

This survives especially in compounds.

Practice 30

> “They received **first-class** service.”

「他們得到**一流的服務**。」

Practice 31

> “The work was of **first-rate** quality.”

「這項工作的質素是**一流的**。」

first = 在品質、等級或評價上屬於最高一級

This is more commonly expressed through compounds than bare **first**.

16. **first-class** = highest standard / excellent (一流的) — 一流的 ; 優質的

Practice 32

> “She received **first-class** care.”

「她得到**一流的照顧**。」

Practice 33

> “The hotel provides **first-class** service.”

「這間酒店提供**一流服務**。」

first-class = 品質、服務或能力達到很高水平的

It can also literally refer to a travel/service class:

> first-class ticket = 頭等票

17. **first class** = highest travel/service category (頭等) — 頭等 ; 一等

Practice 34

> “They travelled **first class**.”

「他們乘坐**頭等艙 / 頭等座**。」

Practice 35

> “She bought a **first-class ticket**.”

「她買了一張**頭等票**。」

****first class = 交通、郵件或某些服務中的最高等級****

18. ****first-hand = directly experienced / obtained (第一手的) — 親身的 ; 第一手的****

A very useful family extension.

Practice 36

> “She has ****first-hand experience**** of the problem.”

「她對這個問題有****親身經驗****。」

Practice 37

> “We received the information ****first-hand****.”

「我們取得了****第一手資料****。」

****first-hand = 直接來自親身經歷、原始來源或當事人的，而非經他人轉述****

19. ****first-hand experience/account (親身經歷 / 第一手描述) — 第一手的****

Practice 38

> “He gave a ****first-hand account**** of the event.”

「他提供了事件的****第一手描述****。」

Practice 39

> “The book is based on ****first-hand experience****.”

「這本書建基於****親身經歷****。」

****first-hand = 資訊 / 經驗直接來自實際參與或觀察****

20. ****first thing = first action / very early (第一件事 / 一大早) — 第一件事 ; 最先****

Practice 40

> “I’ll call her **first thing** tomorrow.”

「我明天**一早第一件事**就會打電話給她。」

Practice 41

> “The **first thing** she does is make tea.”

「她做的**第一件事**就是泡茶。」

first thing = 最先進行的事情；first thing tomorrow/morning 常指一早最先做

21. **first things first** — 先處理最重要 / 最先要做的事

A common fixed expression.

Practice 42

> “**First things first**—let’s make sure everyone is safe.”

「**先處理最重要的事**——我們先確保所有人安全。」

Practice 43

> “First things **first**: we need a plan.”

「**先說最要緊的**：我們需要一個計劃。」

first things first = 先處理最基本、最重要或最應優先完成的事情

22. **in the first place** = originally / as the first reason (首先 / 原本) — 首先；一開始

This expression has two useful uses.

Practice 44

> “Why did you agree in the **first place**?”

「你**當初**為甚麼會同意？」

Practice 45

> “In the **first place**, we do not have enough time.”

「**首先**，我們沒有足夠時間。」

in the first place = 當初 / 原本；或在列舉理由時表示第一個原因

23. **first come, first served** — 先到先得

A common fixed expression.

Practice 46

> “Tickets are available on a **first come, first served** basis.”

「門票採取**先到先得**方式。」

Practice 47

> “Seats are **first come, first served**.”

「座位**先到先得**。」

first come, first served = 最早到達 / 提出要求的人最先獲得服務或資源

24. **from the first** = from the beginning (從一開始) — 從最初

A slightly literary/formal expression.

Practice 48

> “She trusted him **from the first**.”

「她**從一開始**便信任他。」

Practice 49

> “The idea seemed promising **from the first**.”

「這個想法**一開始**就顯得很有希望。」

from the first = 從事情最初開始的時候

Less common than:

> from the beginning

25. **first** = previous earliest version/generation (第一代 / 初版) — 最初的 ; 第一代的

Practice 50

> “The **first version** of the product was much simpler.”

「產品的**第一個版本 / 初版**簡單得多。」

Practice 51

> “The **first generation** of the device had several problems.”

「這款裝置的**第一代**有幾個問題。」

first = 一系列版本、世代或階段中的最早一個

Important distinction: **first** vs **firstly**

first

can naturally organize steps or points:

> “First, listen carefully.”

firstly

is specifically an adverb used to introduce the first point:

> “Firstly, we need more information.”

Both are correct.

First is generally more flexible and often more natural in ordinary speech.

Important distinction: **first** vs **at first**

This is crucial.

****first****

= before doing something else

> “Listen first, then answer.”

「先聽，再回答。」

****at first****

= initially, at the beginning

> “At first, I disagreed.”

「起初，我不同意。」

****At first**** usually implies that something changed later.

Your passage uses ****first****, not ****at first****.

Important distinction: ****first vs for the first time****

****first****

can describe sequence:

> “She listened first.”

= 她先聽。

****for the first time****

means:

> something has never happened before.

> “She visited for the first time.”

= 她第一次到訪。

Very different meanings.

Important distinction: **first vs first of all**

first

can simply indicate sequence:

> “Wash the fruit first.”

first of all

usually organizes discourse or emphasizes the first thing to consider:

> “First of all, thank you.”

So **first of all** is more discourse-oriented.

Important distinction: **first vs earliest**

first

means:

> position number one in a sequence.

earliest

emphasizes:

> the least late / most early in time.

> “the first train”

may mean the first in sequence.

> “the earliest train”

specifically means the train departing at the earliest time.

Often these coincide, but not always.

Important distinction: **first vs primary**

first

can refer to order or priority.

primary

usually means:

> main / most important.

> “our first concern”

and:

> “our primary concern”

can overlap.

But **primary** does not normally mean chronological first.

Important distinction: **first vs main**

first

may mean:

* earliest

* number one

* highest priority

main

means:

> most important or central.

> “the first reason”

= reason mentioned first

> “the main reason”

= most important reason

These need not be the same.

Important distinction: **come first vs be first**

be first

may simply indicate ranking/order.

> “She was first in line.”

come first

can mean ranking:

> “She came first in the race.”

but also priority:

> “Family comes first.”

= 家庭最重要。

Context decides.

Important distinction: **put someone first vs come first**

someone comes first

= they have highest priority.

put someone first

= actively choose to prioritize them.

> “Her family comes first.”

> “She puts her family first.”

The second emphasizes the person's decision/behaviour.

Important distinction: **first-hand vs first**

first

= number/order/priority.

first-hand

= directly experienced or obtained from the original source.

> “first-hand knowledge”

does not mean:

> “knowledge ranked number one.”

It means:

> knowledge gained directly.

Important distinction: **first-class — category vs quality**

Literal category:

> “a first-class ticket”

= 頭等票

Figurative quality:

> “first-class service”

= 一流服務

Same compound, related but distinct modern uses.

Important distinction: **first vs former**

first

= earliest in a sequence.

former

= previous, no longer current.

> “my first job”

= 我的第一份工作

> “my former job”

= 我以前的工作

Your first job may or may not be your most recent former job.

Family-extension note

Following the reference curation style, these are especially useful members and constructions of the **first** family:

- * **first — sequence** = 首先 / 先
- * **first + noun** = 第一個 / 第一項
- * **the first** = 第一個
- * **first — earliest occurrence** = 最早 / 首次
- * **for the first time** = 第一次
- * **at first** = 起初
- * **first of all** = 首先
- * **firstly** = 首先 (較正式列點)
- * **first and foremost** = 首先而且最重要
- * **come first — priority** = 最優先
- * **put someone/something first** = 把……放在首位
- * **first priority/concern** = 首要事項
- * **first place** = 第一名 / 首位
- * **come/finish first** = 得第一 / 最先完成
- * **first-class — excellent** = 一流的
- * **first class — service/travel category** = 頭等
- * **first-hand** = 第一手 / 親身的
- * **first thing** = 第一件事 / 一大早最先
- * **first things first** = 先處理最要緊的事情
- * **in the first place** = 當初 / 首先
- * **first come, first served** = 先到先得
- * **first version/generation** = 第一版 / 第一代

As in the reference examples, **first** is rich mainly because of its **grammatical multifunctionality and fixed expressions**, rather than because it has many completely unrelated lexical meanings. The scanning SOP specifically treats such grammatical pattern shifts as worthwhile learner material.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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first — sequence adverb	在一連串行動中最先進行，之後才做其他事情
first + noun	在順序、時間或排列中位於最前面的
the first	某組人、事物或事件中排最前的一個
first — earliest occurrence	某件事情最早發生的一次或階段
for the first time	某件事以前從未發生，這次是首次
at first	在事情開始的階段；通常暗示後來有所變化
first of all	用來引出一連串內容、理由或步驟中的第一項
firstly	較正式地引出第一個論點 / 原因 / 步驟
first and foremost	在所有考慮中最重要、最優先
come first — priority	在重要性或優先次序上高於其他事情
put someone/something first	主動把某人 / 某事的需要或重要性放在最高優先次序
first priority/concern	最需要優先處理或考慮的事情
first place	比賽、排名或競爭中的最高位置
come/finish first	在比賽或完成順序中排在所有其他人之前
first-class — excellent	品質、服務或能力達到很高水平的
first class — category	交通、郵件或服務中的最高等級
first-hand	直接來自親身經歷、原始來源或當事人的
first thing	最先進行的事情；亦可指一早最先做的事
first things first	先處理最基本、最重要或最應優先完成的事情
in the first place — originally	表示當初 / 原本的情況
in the first place — first reason	引出第一個理由或考慮
first come, first served	最早到達 / 提出要求的人最先獲得服務或資源
first version/generation	一系列版本、世代或階段中的最早一個

For your original sentence

> “Instead, she listens **first** and then gives simple but thoughtful advice.”

The exact meaning is:

first = 在一連串行動中先進行；在做下一件事之前先做這件事

Therefore:

> **she listens first**

= **「她會先聽清楚對方說甚麼，再作回應」**

The word **then** makes the sequence especially clear:

> **first → then**

> **listen first → give advice afterward**

So this is not:

> **at first** = 起初

nor:

> **for the first time** = 第一次

nor:

> **come first** = 最優先

It is the straightforward **sequence-order sense**:

> **先做 A，然後做 B**.